

Tennis - Understanding Your Coach

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. Pre-teach: 20 words you'll actually hear from a coach

From this video (10):

#	Word / phrase	Meaning
1	grip	how you hold the racket handle – the coach compares it to a handshake
2	forehand	a shot hit with the front of your hand facing the ball, on your dominant side
3	point the racket	aim the racket face towards where you want the ball to go
4	volley	hitting the ball before it bounces
5	bounce	when the ball hits the ground
6	compression	how much a ball squashes on impact – softer/slower balls give beginners more time to react
7	swing	a full, wide motion of the racket – the coach says volleys need a push, not a swing
8	push forward	a short, controlled motion (used for volleys instead of a full swing)
9	racket face	the flat, strung part of the racket that hits the ball
10	racket back to the middle	returning the racket to a central, ready position between shots

General tennis vocabulary (10) - for the actual on-court lesson:

#	Word / phrase	Meaning
11	backhand	a shot hit across your body, on your non-dominant side
12	serve	the shot that starts a point
13	rally	a series of shots back and forth before the point ends
14	baseline	the back line of the court
15	net	the barrier the ball must go over
16	ready position	standing balanced, knees bent, ready to move in any direction

#	Word / phrase	Meaning
17	court	the marked playing area
18	service box	the marked area the serve must land in
19	fault	a serve that doesn't land in the correct box
20	racket (also spelled racquet)	the equipment you hit the ball with

2. Reading (5-7 min)

Before you even hit a ball, your coach will check your grip – one coach compares it to shaking someone's hand. Once you're holding the racket properly, the idea is simple: point the racket where you want the ball to go. Beginners often start with softer, slower-compression balls, which bounce more gently and give you more time to react, instead of feeling rushed. For volleys – hitting the ball before it bounces – your coach won't ask you to swing at all, just to push the racket forward and bring it back to the middle, ready for the next shot. Coaches repeat the same few instructions constantly – not because you're doing badly, but because good habits in tennis are built through repetition.

Comprehension questions: 1. What does the coach compare the grip to? 2. Why do beginners often use softer, slower balls? 3. What's the difference between a volley and a normal shot, in terms of the swing? 4. Where should you return your racket to after a shot?

3. Writing (5-7 min)

Choose one: - **A.** Write 5 instructions your coach might give you during your first lesson, using at least 5 words from the list above. - **B.** Write a short diary entry (6-8 sentences) titled "My first tennis lesson", imagining what happened, using at least 6 words from the list.

4. Oral comprehension - video task (8-10 min)

Second listen - gap-fill. Hand out these lines with blanks; students fill in the missing word(s) as they watch again.

- "If you pretend you were going to shake somebody's _____, and then you hold your racket like that."
- "Just pointing your racket where you want _____ to go."
- "If we can try and keep our racket away from our _____ a little bit."

4. "The ball bounces a bit slower and lets us have more _____ to hit the ball properly."
5. "We're not going to _____ at all – we're gonna just push forward."
6. "What you're gonna try and do is try and put your racket back to the _____ every time."

True/false check (correct against the real transcript): - The coach compares holding the racket to shaking hands. - For volleys, the coach tells the student to swing hard. - The coach says the softer balls bounce faster than normal balls.

5. Oral expression: imperative vs diplomatic register

Same idea as the horse riding session. Items marked are for B1-B2 students; everyone should be comfortable with the plain imperative column.

Imperative (everyone)	Diplomatic (B1-B2)
Watch the ball.	Could you keep your eyes on the ball, please?
Bend your knees.	Would you mind bending your knees a little more?
Get in ready position.	Could you get into position for me?
Follow through.	Could you try to follow through a bit more?
Turn side-on.	Would you turn side-on to the net, please?
Hit it higher over the net.	Could you aim a little higher over the net?
Move your feet.	Would you mind moving your feet more?
Serve into the box.	Could you try to land your serve in the box?
Wait for the bounce.	Would you wait for it to bounce first, please?
Try again.	Shall we try that one again?

Tennis - Understanding Your Coach

Video (British coaching)

Tennis Made Easy | How to Hit – <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PCmdZZZ5kMo>
Official LTA (Lawn Tennis Association – British governing body) video. The coach has a Northern English accent – clear and understandable, good authentic listening practice. He coaches from a wheelchair (he lost both legs) – worth a low-key mention if it comes up naturally, but no need to make it the focus. Very short (under 2 minutes), which makes it ideal for repeated listening rather than a single pass – play it two or three times with different tasks each time.

6. Game / role-play (10 min)

"Coach Says" (same format as the horse riding version – reuse across sports so students recognise the pattern) - One student is the coach, the rest mime the actions (an imaginary racket works fine, or use real rackets if available). - The coach calls out commands from the list above. Players only obey if preceded by *"Coach says..."* – otherwise freeze. Anyone who moves without "Coach says" is out. - **Twist for B1-B2 students:** the coach can also use the diplomatic versions.

Alternative / extension - "Red, Orange, Green" - Directly borrowed from the LTA's own ball-colour progression, turned into a reaction game: call **"Red!"** (freeze/stop), **"Orange!"** (walk/slow shadow-swing), **"Green!"** (fast footwork/full shadow-swing). Good energy-burner, and it recycles real LTA vocabulary rather than inventing an unrelated game.

Same six-part structure as horse riding – next up: basketball, once you've had a chance to look this over.

About this activity

Same structure as the horse riding template – all four skills, one theme ~45–50 min total, can be split across two sessions

1. Pre-teach: 20 words you'll actually hear from a coach

Matching worksheet – paste into the Daily Vocabulary Generator (Day 1 matching / Day 2 test) or use as-is.

2. Reading (5–7 min)

Short text – hand out or project. Ask comprehension questions after (below).

4. Oral comprehension - video task (8-10 min)

Now that we have the real transcript, this can be a proper listening exercise rather than a placeholder – and since the clip is under 2 minutes, playing it 2–3 times is easy.

****First listen – gist.**** While watching, students note down every instruction the coach gives (aim for at least 4–5). Compare in pairs afterwards.

4. Oral comprehension - video task (8-10 min)

1. 1. hand 2. ball 3. body 4. time 5. swing 6. middle
2. The coach compares holding the racket to shaking hands. → True
3. For volleys, the coach tells the student to swing hard. → False – push forward, no swing
4. The coach says the softer balls bounce faster than normal balls. → False – slower